to female entrepreneurs in regions with low female labor-force participation.[8] By providing small-scale financial support, initiatives like We-Fi help individuals, and particularly women, build businesses, improve livelihoods, and foster economic resilience in their communities.

These efforts underscore a broader trend among IOs: connecting more directly with the people they serve. By supporting local priorities, addressing critical needs, and empowering underserved populations, IOs demonstrate that their mission is not just about macrolevel development but also about uplifting individuals and communities at the grassroots level.

MEDIA CAMPAIGNS

In chapter 7, we explored how how social media has transformed the way IOs engage with the public. These platforms offer IOs a direct line to domestic audiences, enabling them to counter populist narratives and adopt people-centric language that resonates with ordinary citizens. Historically, IOs have often been perceived as opaque, elitist, and disconnected from the public, largely because their communication has typically been channeled through domestic leaders and policy officials. As a result, their rhetoric has rarely reached the everyday people whose lives their policies aim to improve.

Social media provides a unique opportunity for IOs to break down these barriers and foster a sense of accessibility and transparency. By engaging directly with domestic audiences, IOs can demystify their actions and intentions, making them appear more relatable and accountable. This strategy can also serve to enhance their legitimacy, as transparency builds trust and undercuts populist attempts to scapegoat IOs or misrepresent their policies. Research shows that such outreach can increase public awareness and bolster trust in IOs, particularly in advanced democracies where skepticism toward multilateral institutions is often high (Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023).

By adopting these strategies proactively, IOs can better position themselves to handle the challenges posed by populist leaders in influential member states. We hope the specific policy options outlined in this section serve as valuable tools for policymakers within IOs and member-state governments, equipping them to strengthen institutional resilience.